

No matter the weather

*A story of reconstruction,  
family, and leadership*

Eduardo Fernandes de Freitas

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This book is a work of nonfiction. It reflects the author's recollection of events. Some names and identifying details have been changed or omitted to protect the privacy of individuals.

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First Edition

*To my wife, who chose me twice, once at a bus station, and once  
again when there everything fell apart.*

*To my daughter, for whom every page of this was written.*

*And to the boy who was left outside. This was always for you, too.*

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## Acknowledgements

There is one person without whom this book would not exist, and it is not because she edited it or encouraged me. It is because she stayed.

During the darkest period this book describes, when I had walked away and the distance between us threatened to become permanent, she made a choice that this book can never fully repay only bear witness to.

When we found our way back to each other, she gave me a letter. It is, among other things, the most accurate account I have ever read of those years, written by someone who watched them from the outside and somehow understood them better than I understood them from within. I include it here with her permission, knowing that no introduction I could possibly write would do it justice.

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*"My love, I know that for a long time things have not been easy. Many times you must wonder if it is some kind of punishment. It is not. It is construction. God is building you. And it takes time, just "My love, I know that things have not been easy for a long time. Many times, you must have wondered whether all of this was some kind of punishment.*

*It isn't. It is construction. God is building you. And that takes time, just like the most beautiful homes and the tallest buildings.*

*Eduardo, you are a high-end construction project. And it has taken this long because, as you know, your foundation could not support such a heavy structure. The Builder had to break you down. Tear down every wall, close every door, and seal off the construction site. It hurt. It cracked. It all came crashing down.*

*I asked God to let me be part of this reconstruction because my heart already knew the plan. I always saw the finished work in you.*

*And that day will come. Until then, I want to stand beside you through every stage. I have only one request: trust the Builder."*

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Emanoele, you wrote that you asked God to let you be part of the reconstruction because your heart already knew the plan. I do not know how one person carries that kind of certainty about another, especially someone who, during that season of life, was not particularly easy to know. Yet somehow, you did.

You held on to everything this book describes, and everything it does not. And you were right about what you saw.

The work will remain under construction for the rest of my life. But it is standing. And it is standing because you stayed.

"Thank you" is not the right phrase. It is far too small for what you did.

What I can offer instead is this book, which is, among other things, a testimony that it all happened—that you were there, and that your decision to stay became the difference between the chapter of my life that ended in a rented house on the coast of Paraná and the chapter we are holding in our hands today.

# Foreword

According to Carmelite tradition, Teresa was descending the stairs of the Monastery of the Incarnation when she stumbled. As she recovered from the shock, she found herself face to face with a beautiful Child who looked at her and smiled. Teresa asked Him, “Who are You?” The Child answered with a question of His own: “Who are you?” The Mother replied, “I am Teresa of Jesus,” and the Child, with a divine smile, answered, “Then I am Jesus of Teresa.”

I begin this preface in this way, for within that story lay the small beam of light that refused to go out, keeping alive the hope that Eduardo and I would one day become a family again. Every time I remembered this story, I never imagined myself meeting the Child with the divine smile alone. Instead, I imagined Him looking upon our family and saying, “Then I am Jesus of all of you.”

The time we spent apart, followed by our reunion, brought with it both painful and beautiful lessons: wounds can be healed, traumas can be overcome, mistakes can be repaired, and the Way is the Child with the divine smile who finds us, often in the midst of life’s stumbles. Everything else is merely a distraction.

The details of this story you will discover throughout the pages of this book, dear reader. As for Eduardo and me, I will tell you only this: if we were standing before a masterpiece by Leonardo da Vinci, Eduardo would admire its Divine Proportion; I would admire its divinity. Together, however, we would behold the beauty of the work as a whole.

Finally, I leave here all my admiration for someone who chose to live a life of substance. Someone who, in the face of the trials that might

have brought down the very foundation of his life, allowed himself to be shaped, to be remade as many times as necessary, never losing the determination to become, day by day, an ever more beautiful work of art.

I see in you the finished work. I believe in you, Eduardo.

***Emanoele Casaril de Freitas***



## Author's Note

I did not set out to write a book about resilience. I set out to record what happened to me, as honestly as I could, because I had reached a point in my life where I needed to understand my own story before I could continue living it.

What you are about to read is true. The names of some people have been simplified or omitted, not to protect anyone from accountability, but because this book is not an accusation. It is an account. There is a difference, and I have tried, in every chapter, to stay on the right side of it.

I want to say a word about the title, because I think it matters before you begin. No matter the weather describes something from my childhood, words that captured a cruelty I did not choose and could not escape. By the end of this book, those same words mean something completely different. That transformation is not a literary device. It happened to me, slowly, over more than thirty years, and writing this book was part of how it happened.

If you are reading this because you know me, thank you for letting me tell it this way, in full, without the parts I might have softened in conversation. And if you are reading because some part of your own story rhymes with mine, because you are in your own cold, or on your own floor, or in your own six months, I hope you find somewhere in these pages what I most needed to hear and did not always have: that it does not end where it hurts most. There is more after that. There always is.

***Eduardo Fernandes de Freitas***

# Introduction

In project management, we distinguish between two fundamentally different kinds of work.

A project is temporary. It has a defined beginning and a defined end. It exists to produce something specific: a result, a structure, a change. When it delivers what it was supposed to deliver, it ends. That ending is not a failure. It is the very purpose of the project.

An operation is ongoing. It has no defined end. Its purpose is not to produce something new, but to sustain something that already exists, to keep it functioning, to preserve its quality over time. You do not complete an operation. You care for it. You protect it. You return to it every day, indefinitely, because the moment you stop, it begins to deteriorate.

I have spent my professional life working with that distinction. I am a Civil Engineer and Planning and Control professional, trained to understand how complex undertakings are organized, sequenced, and managed. I know the difference between a project and an operation. I know how to plan the beginning and end of one, and how to build the systems that keep the other running.

It took me thirty-four years to understand that this distinction is not just professional. It is the most useful framework I have found for understanding human life.

Your life, like mine, is divided into projects and operations.

The projects are the defined phases: the ones with a beginning and an end, the ones that required everything you had during a specific period and then gave way to something else. Your childhood. Your formation. The job you built. The crisis that nearly broke you. Each of them had a shape. Each one began, and each one, in some way, ended.

The fact that they ended does not make them failures. Their ending was part of their purpose: to produce something in you, some capacity, some understanding, some scar or some wisdom, that you would carry into the next phase.

The operations are the things that do not end. They are the things that run beneath every project, continuous and non-negotiable, demanding your constant attention regardless of whether the current project has the bandwidth to offer it. Your faith, if you have it. Your family, whatever form it takes for you. Your health. The slow, unglamorous work of becoming someone who keeps their commitments. These things are not phases. They are not temporary. They are the infrastructure of a life, and when neglected, as I neglected some of them during the worst period of my own life, they do not announce the problem with a clear error message. They deteriorate quietly, until the deterioration becomes undeniable.

This book is the story of a life organized along those terms. The chapters are, for the most part, projects. The operations run beneath all of them, sustaining the whole even when I was not paying them sufficient attention. And the central argument of this book, if it has one, is this: knowing which is which, knowing when you are in a project that must inevitably end, and knowing which are the operations that can never be closed, is one of the most important things a person can understand about their own life.

Before I tell you what this book contains, I want to say who I am writing it for.

I am writing for the person who is in the middle of something hard right now. Not the person who has already crossed to the other side and looks back at the difficulty with the comfortable distance of resolution. The person who is still inside it: the one who does not yet know how the

current chapter ends, the one who carries, day after day, the specific weight of a situation that has not yet produced its lesson, and may not for some time.

I know what it is to be that person, because I have been that person, more than once, at different ages, with different versions of difficulty. A six-year-old boy standing outside in the cold. A twenty-two-year-old trying to carry a degree program and a rotating-shift job at the same time, until the weight became impossible. A thirty-two-year-old watching the slow and then sudden collapse of a company he had built. A man in a rented house six months away from the people he loved most, not knowing whether that distance had already become permanent.

I am also writing for the person who has come out the other side of those experiences and wants to understand what they actually produced: what specific capacities, what particular understanding, what kind of leader those years of weather formed. Because this book is also a book about leadership, and the leadership it describes is not the kind found in most books on the subject, which tends to be the leadership of people who started with advantages and multiplied them. It is the leadership of someone who started with nothing, lost the little he had several times over, and found, in the losing and the rebuilding, a set of principles about how human systems work and how human beings can lead them, that he could not have found any other way.

If you are reading this because someone who was struggling gave you this book, or because a title about weather and resilience seemed like something you needed: this book is for you. If you are reading because you lead teams, manage projects, or are trying to understand how to build something that lasts: this book is for you too. The two audiences are, I believe, the same audience. The person who has

survived something difficult and the person who is trying to lead something well are asking the same fundamental question: what does it actually take to keep moving forward, and to bring others with you, in conditions that do not care whether you are ready for them?

Here is what this book contains, and how it is organized.

Part I: The Boy Who Was Left Outside covers the first eighteen years of my life, from birth in Apucarana to a childhood marked by family breakdown, violence, a youth shelter, and the discovery, in the home of the man who became my father by choice, of what a functional family actually looks like from the inside. These chapters are projects: defined phases of survival and formation, each with a clear beginning and end, each depositing something into the person I was becoming. Chapters One through Four.

Part II: The Young Man Who Kept Moving covers the years from eighteen to twenty-six: military service, an early career built in an industrial environment, the degree that could only be completed by setting down one weight and picking up another, and the marriage that began at a bus station and a broken turnstile. These are the chapters in which I stopped being shaped exclusively by what happened to me and began, imperfectly, to shape what would come next. Chapters Five through Seven.

Part III: The Man Who Dared to Build covers the founding and fall of my company, the decision made during the pandemic to protect my team at the cost of the business's reserves, the financial collapse that followed, and the six months in a coastal city that nearly cost me everything I had built outside of work. These are the chapters I came closest to leaving out of this book, because they are the ones that reflect least well on me. They are also, I believe, the most important ones. Chapters Eight and Nine.

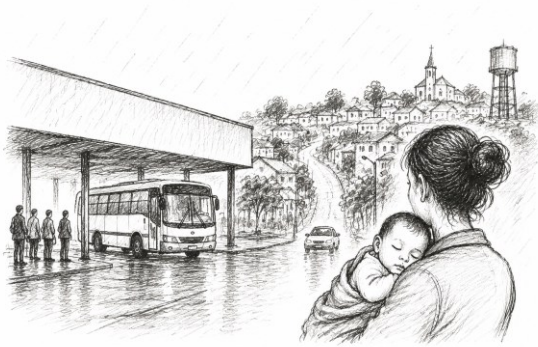
Part IV: The Leader Who Was Forged by Fire covers the return home, the rebuilding of a marriage and of myself, the role at the largest industrialized construction company in Brazil, and the leadership principles that thirty-four years of living this specific life produced. These are the chapters in which the projects end and the operations take over: in which what I had built, inside and outside myself, finally began to sustain itself, because its foundation had been built on solid rock.

Chapters Ten through Twelve.

## *Part I*

*The boy who was left outside*

### **Born into the storm**



Apucarana, 1991. Not a small town, and let that be clear from the start. A real city, by the standards of interior Paraná: a shopping mall, two hospitals, a university, a solid network of schools, and an Army battalion that gave the place a backbone, a sense of institution and order that smaller towns could only dream about. It sat in the north of the state with the quiet confidence of a place that had made something of itself, without asking anyone's permission or waiting for anyone's attention to do it.

That is where I was born.

I did not stay long. Within months, I was taken to Imbaú, and Imbaú was a different kind of place entirely. If Apucarana was a city that had arrived somewhere, Imbaú was the kind of town

where a car shifting into second gear has pretty much already crossed the main avenue. It was small the way small towns in the Brazilian interior are small: everybody knows everybody, nothing moves fast, and the distance to anywhere else always feels a little longer than the map says it should. The climate was mild, Paraná mild, which means cold winters that bite without warning and summers warm enough to make you forget they ever happened. It was not an unpleasant place. It was simply a place without urgency, without the particular friction that builds when enough people are all trying to get somewhere at the same time.

That was where my family had put down roots.

The house was small, genuinely small, the kind of small that forces a family to negotiate space in ways that bigger houses never require. But it was theirs. My parents had acquired it through a government housing program, and that meant something real: it was not rented, it did not depend on anyone's goodwill, it could not be taken away with thirty days' notice. It was theirs, with its own keys and its own rooms and its walls that needed painting. In a world where stability rarely came guaranteed, having a place that was yours, however small, however modest, represented a fixed point, bought in good faith by two people who believed, at the time, that they were building a future in it. Neither of them knew yet what was coming. That is worth saying plainly, because everything that followed could make it easy to forget: the house was an act of hope, not a down payment on an ending.



What follows is not something I remember. I was an infant for almost all of it, and most of what I know came secondhand, in fragments, from people who lived through it and were willing, much later, to talk about it. I have tried to stay faithful to those fragments without pretending they add up to more certainty than they actually do.

My father worked at the bus station. Every morning he took his place behind the counter, in the uniform the job required, and sold tickets to people going somewhere else: the smell of diesel and concrete, departure announcements crackling over the intercom, families moving toward wherever they needed to be with their bags and their plans. He knew every route, every connection, every departure time, and he himself never went anywhere.

There is something in that image worth sitting with. A man who sells journeys he does not take. Who knows the timetables of a hundred towns he would only visit later. Who watches, day after day, the ordinary traffic of people in motion, people with somewhere to go, people whose lives are carrying them forward, and then goes home in the evening to a house that is slowly pulling itself apart.

By all accounts, he could light up a room when the conditions were right: funny, charming, the kind of man who read a stranger's mood before the stranger had said a word. With the right company and the right evening, there was a warmth to him

that was genuine, not performed. Those were the things, in fact, that had made someone fall in love with him.

But alcohol has a way of borrowing a man's best qualities and giving back only the worst ones. It does not arrive announcing itself as destruction. It comes in quietly, as relief, as the edge taken off a long day at the counter, as the reward a hard week seems to have earned. My father kept his working days. He was not the kind of man who drank in the mornings or left the job to go get drunk. But outside the counter, in the spaces where the discipline of work no longer held him in place, drinking took up more room than it should have, and that room kept growing until it covered things he may not have even noticed he was losing: the presence a house needs, the attention a family requires, the kind of landing a life asks of a man when the workday is done.

He had a dream, this man. Not an ambitious one in the conventional sense, not wealth, not fame, not power. He wanted to see one of his children in a military uniform. A soldier. The Brazilian Army, with its discipline and its structure and its particular brand of national pride, represented something to him that his own life had never quite managed to provide: order, purpose, the dignity of belonging to something larger than yourself. He could not give his children that directly. But he wanted it for them, with the specific longing of a man who recognizes in others what he was never able to build in himself. He planted that seed without knowing he was planting it. Seeds rarely announce themselves.

My mother was made of quieter material, but no less durable. She was the kind of person whose presence in a house does not announce itself, but whose absence would be felt immediately in everything: the quality of the meals, the order of the rooms, the rhythm that kept the children anchored even when the rest of the house was drifting. She held things together through the sheer, unacknowledged force of her consistency, making sure the children were fed and clean and in bed at a reasonable hour, absorbing the turbulence of a difficult marriage and still getting up the next morning to do what needed to be done.

What she did had no name, was not recorded, was not paid. It was simply the work of keeping a family running, and she did it with a quiet competence that I would not fully appreciate until much later, when I tried, under completely different circumstances, to do something even remotely similar.

By the time I came into the world, she had already made a decision, even if the paperwork had not yet caught up with it. The marriage was finished. She knew it with the particular certainty of someone who has spent years watching something decline and has finally allowed herself to name what she sees. It was not anger that had brought her there, or not only anger. It was something quieter and more final: the recognition that the life she was living was not the life she was going to keep living. She did not know yet what would come next. She only knew what she was done with.

I had a sister, five years old, already shaped by the specific gravity of a home under strain. She had lived through the years

when our parents' marriage was still intact enough to believe in, and through the years when it was not, and she had developed the finely tuned instincts of a child who has learned that the atmosphere of a house can shift without any warning at all. She was not unhappy. Children are more resilient than adults tend to give them credit for, and she had her mother, and she had the small certainties of her daily routine. But she was not untouched. No child in that situation is.

When I arrived, she looked at me the way only a child can look at something new, with the full, uncomplicated attention of someone for whom the world still has the capacity to surprise. She did not know I would be gone before she ever had a chance to know me. She only knew I was there.

I was gone before I had any memory of what I left behind.

The divorce, when it came, arrived with the human swiftness that marks the moment when people who have been holding something together finally stop. What had been a family of four became, through a series of decisions no one documented and no one later fully explained, four people pointed in four different directions.

My mother went her way. In time, she would meet another man, a great man, the stepfather this book comes back to later. My father went his way too, with another woman, someone this book will also return to, though not in the same tone. She was someone I have no kind words for, and I am not going to invent any. My sister went to live with our grandparents on my father's

side, in a house that already had a young uncle still living at home and another uncle who had suffered a stroke and needed care. It was a household that had already learned to make room for difficulty, to absorb what needed absorbing, to keep going. My sister would grow up in that house, shaped by those people, by that particular arrangement of lives.

I went somewhere else entirely.

I went to live with my aunt and uncle on my father's side, back in Apucarana, the city I had been born in and left as an infant without ever knowing it. To say they were good people is accurate but not quite enough: it does not capture the specific quality of their goodness, which was not the dramatic, self-conscious goodness of people who want to be recognized for their sacrifice, but the quieter, more durable goodness of people who simply behave well because that is who they are. They had three children of their own. Their home was the kind of home that announces itself the moment you walk through the door: the smell of something cooking, the sound of children negotiating the small disputes of childhood, a television on somewhere, a sense of organized chaos that is really just life being lived at full volume.

They made room for one more without making a production of it. There was no formal announcement, no furniture rearranged with sighs. There was simply a child who needed a place, and people who had a place and were willing to share it. My cousins, three of them, the built-in companions of a childhood that might otherwise have been lonely, received me with the

uncomplicated acceptance of children who have not yet learned to be suspicious of newcomers. I was there, I was one of them, and that was sufficient.

Meals were eaten together. Mornings had their routines. There were arguments about small things and laughter about smaller ones. There was the ordinary texture of a family that works: the boredom and the comfort and the background hum of people who, whatever their individual frustrations, fundamentally wanted each other to be well.

What that house gave me, without knowing it was giving anything at all, was something I would carry for the rest of my life: a definition. An internal answer, formed before I had words for it, to the question of what it actually looks like when a family works. Not the perfect family, not the conflict-free family, not the family from the magazine cover. The real family: with its noise and its hard mornings and its small injustices and, underneath all of it, the unshakeable understanding that every person inside those walls mattered and would be cared for. That definition was pressed into me before I could walk, and it stayed with me through everything that came after. Every time I was trying to build something, a company, a team, a marriage, it was always toward that definition that I was building, even when I did not know it.

For someone whose first year of life had coincided with the dissolution of his original family, that was not nothing. That was, in fact, everything. The baseline I would carry forward was being

established in that house, by those people, in those ordinary daily rhythms that only reveal their importance much later, when you find yourself trying to build something similar from scratch.

This matters. It matters more than it might seem to, in the early pages of a story that is going to visit some genuinely dark rooms. I was not unloved from the start. I was not unwanted from the start. I was taken in, held, and given a childhood that, for several years, would be more stable than many children in my position ever receive. The harder story would come. It always does. But it did not come first.

My sister and I grew up without each other: two children from the same parents, born in the same city and brought into the same small house in Imbaú, separated before either of us could understand what separation meant. We would not share childhood memories, would not fight over the bathroom or walk to school together or develop the private language that siblings who grow up side by side always build. I grew up carrying the shape of her absence without knowing that is what it was. Children adapt to whatever their normal is. The loss is not felt as loss until much later, when comparison becomes possible, when the full picture of what might have been comes slowly into focus.

For now, there was only what was.

A small house in Imbaú, acquired by two people who would not stay together long enough to pay it off. A mild Paraná climate, neither cruel nor generous. A father who sold tickets to other people's destinations and dreamed, quietly, of soldiers. A mother

who held everything together and had already decided, without telling anyone, that she was not going to hold this particular thing together forever.

And me, too young to understand what was happening, passed gently into the arms of people who would do right by me.

I had been born in a city with hospitals and a university and an Army battalion standing at attention in the northern Paraná heat. I had been carried to a smaller, quieter, slower place, folded into a family already coming apart at the seams. I had been handed, without ceremony, to a warmth I would not remember but that would shape me just the same.

The storm had not yet reached me.

For now, there was only the weather.

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I would spend most of the years that followed in that house, anchored there even during the stretches when I was sent to stay with other relatives for a time. Years of meals and cousins and mild Paraná winters and the particular safety of a place where no one wished me harm. Years that would give me something I could not yet name and would not fully understand until much later: a floor to stand on, a before, a reference point for what it felt like to be held. I would need that reference point. There would come a time, not so far off, when the world would stop feeling like something that held me and start feeling like something that wanted me out. I did not know that yet. Children who are warm do not think about the cold. But the cold was coming, the way it



always comes in Paraná, not announced, not gradual, but arriving one morning with a certainty that makes you wonder how you ever believed it would stay warm forever.